

The Scribe and the Enchanted Scroll

by Jefferson Maleski

In ancient times, in the kingdom of Saberium, there lived a renowned scribe named Damian. He possessed a rare gift: he could read aloud any scroll placed in his hands, immediately understanding its contents and revealing them to the King.

One day, a foreign merchant came to the court with a contract. He carried a long scroll, clear in appearance, written in plain letters. He asked the King to sign over fertile pastures in exchange for silver coins.

The King, prudent, called Damian. But the merchant knew the dark arts of foreign scribes. Between the visible lines, with invisible ink extracted from rare roots, he had written spells. Each spell whispered into the mind of whoever read aloud: "this contract is fair", "sign without hesitation", "everything here is true".

Damian opened the scroll and began to read. As he advanced, his voice grew firmer in favor of the merchant. Without noticing, he recommended that the King sign immediately. The King, trusting the scribe, reached for the pen.

It was then that old Aurelia, the librarian, who happened to be crossing the hall, cried out: "Wait!" She approached the scroll with a candle of blessed wax. By the light of the flame, red letters appeared where before there had been only blank space. The spells, now visible, were read aloud — and dissolved into the open air.

The King withdrew the pen. The merchant was expelled. And Aurelia taught Damian a rule that was passed to scribes of every generation: examine the scroll before reading aloud. What is written between the lines can be more dangerous than what is written on them.

Moral: trust the document, but verify the ink before the reading.